

The Nightmare

Aya was back in that hall—the same one from her vision—though she wasn't sure how she'd gotten here. The lights flickered; the cold metal pressed in from all sides. In the distance, an agonized shriek—the pain ripping the voice itself into pieces. A second scream joined in, its pitch clashing discordantly with the first, causing the air itself to writhe in agony. Aya knew these voices. She took off running down the hall, gunning for the door at the end, blood pooling out from underneath it. As she ran, the hallway stretched, further and further. The distance made her feel smaller than she'd ever felt before; her feet moved as though she were dragging cinder blocks behind her. As she splashed into the puddle of blood, the voices suddenly cut out, silenced as if by force, their echoes the only proof they had been real.

Aya threw the door open. In the dimly lit room, a clockwork doctor stood between the tables—despite being twice her size, it looked startlingly like herself. The robot held a buzzsaw in one hand and a multitool in the other—*her* multitool. The tools, the saw, the tables—they were all dripping with blood. Aya began to reach for her gun; that's when she saw them:

Kira and Elyssa were standing in the shadows, eyes glowing an unnatural red color, watching silently.

As the pair stood there, the doctor clicked in Ziklight. Aya didn't catch all of it—something about requiring aid. In response, Kira and Elyssa moved into the center of the room. Here, Aya could see them more clearly. She wished she couldn't. Each of them had a clockwork core embedded in their chests, just below their necks. The flesh around it was jagged and torn. Their clothes hung in tatters over them; patches of skin had been ripped off from either of them, with scraps of metal welded to the skin in places, leaving burnt flesh curling around the edges. Elyssa's jaw had been removed, a clockwork lightning launcher embedded in its place, while Kira's left arm had been severed at the elbow and stripped of flesh—a buzzsaw was welded directly to the bone, with clockwork pieces running up the length of the arm in place of where her muscles should have been. Aya froze; this couldn't be real. The approaching pair weren't her parents—this was a dream, right? It *had* to be. The dream parents reached out for their daughter, their hands slipping through her like an illusion—except, they didn't. The horrors grabbed Aya by her arms and lifted her into the air—something a dream couldn't do. Option B, then—these were custom-made horrors designed specifically to torment her for her declaration of war. Clearly, they couldn't have done this to her real parents—Kira and Elyssa were too clever, they'd have escaped... right?

Aya begin fighting to break free, but the fakes were too strong; they slammed Aya onto one of the tables, splattering blood up into the air, and the doctor strapped her in. Just then, an alarm rang out through the facility. In the distance, Aya heard the familiar footsteps of her friends. Miji yelled out for Aya, assuring her that they were coming to save her. The doctor once again issued a flurry of Ziklight commands—this time, Aya was too distracted to catch anything. The three horrors then ran out the door, their footsteps echoing through the hallway, growing louder, until it sounded as though a hundred constructs were marching towards her friends.

A clash broke out, then a shriek—it was *Soluna*. Why was she here?? A few moments later, a blast of lightning rang out—Nylos cried out for Lyania as well. As Aya struggled helplessly against her restraints, the battle raged on. And then, as quickly as it began, it was over. The doctor’s Ziklight rang out through the hallway. As Aya worked to translate it, her thoughts were interrupted by the sound of a buzzsaw. Aya cried out, tears unable to flow, voice faltering as she tried desperately to make the horrors leave her friends alone—to no effect. After what felt like an eternity, the doctor returned to the room, accompanied by Kira and Elyssa, who gathered around Aya’s table. Other footsteps began to splash into the room through the pool of blood, now even larger than before. The face of Silvanus Starlily, now with glowing red eyes, moved into view above Aya, followed by Nylos, Miji, Khelour, the Creator, Lyania, and, of course, Soluna, last of the Asrian people. As the doctor flipped through Aya’s multitool, Kira’s head jolted to the side; a spark of electricity jolted off her, crackling into her crystal. For just a moment, Kira’s eyes returned to their original green color—she wasn’t a fake—and she looked down at her daughter.

“You did this; why didn’t you save us?”